

Image 9.1: West and East Pakistan, which later became the independent country of Bangladesh
Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

After sacking Sheikh Abdullah in 1953, the government in New Delhi had ramped up financial assistance to Jammu and Kashmir to aid its economic development, with the planning commission committing to the state a sum that was then equivalent to US$15 million. But Abdullah's successor, Bakshi Ghulam Mohammed made no secret of his policy of buying out the support of Kashmiris; he came from a family of businessmen who had benefitted from military contracts and forest leases. Bakshi reached out to Abdullah's supporters and awarded contracts and licences for forestland, transport and tourism, always asking for a price. Even though all this was quietly managed, unfortunately, all Kashmiris began to be viewed as people who would do anything for money. In reality, it was only the middle class that benefitted from these sops. Ironically though, this class had always been supportive of Pakistan, observes Wajahat Habibullah, an Indian civil servant who spent most of his career in the state, in his book, *My Kashmir: The Dying of the Light.*[1]